Please rest assured that it doesn't. In fact, the original draft of this book included unit tests for all code examples. In the end, I found that those tests distracted from the metaprogramming techniques that are the meat of the book, so the tests fell on the cutting-room floor. This doesn't mean you shouldn't write tests for your own metaprogramming endeavors.

On those occasions where I did show test code in this book, I used the test-unit library. Until Ruby 2.1, test-unit was a standard library. From Ruby 2.2 onward, you need to install it as a gem, with the command gem install test-unit.

Ruby Versions

Ruby is continuously changing and improving. However, this very fluidity can be problematic when you try a piece of code on the latest version of the language, only to find that it doesn't work anymore. This is not overly common, but it can happen with metaprogramming, which pushes Ruby to its limits.

This book is written for Ruby 2. As I write, Ruby 2.1 is the most recent stable version of the language, and it's mostly compatible with Ruby 2.0. Some people still run older versions of Ruby, which miss a few important features from 2.x—notably, Refinements and Module#prepend. In the text, I'll refer to Ruby 2.x, and I'll tell you which features were introduced either in Ruby 2.1 or in Ruby 2.0.

When I talk about Ruby versions, I'm talking about the "official" interpreter (sometimes called MRI for *Matz's Ruby Interpreter*[1]). There are many alternate Ruby implementations. Two of the most popular ones are JRuby, which runs on the Java Virtual Machine,[2] and Rubinius.[3] Alternate implementations usually take a few versions to catch up with MRI — so if you use one of them, be aware that some of the examples in this book might not yet work on your interpreter.

Book Editions

The first edition of this book focused on Ruby 1.8, which has since been deprecated. I updated the text to reflect the new features in Ruby, especially the ones that have been introduced by Ruby 2.x.

The chapters in Part II use the Rails source code as a source of examples. Rails has changed a lot since the first edition, so these chapters are almost a complete rewrite of the first edition's content.

1. http://www.ruby-lang.org
2. http://jruby.codehaus.org
3. http://rubini.us/